AI vs DOCTOR: THE



Delhi. What this ends up in is delayed diagnosis, aggravated inflammation, prolonged pain, or months lost to ineffective self-treatment. Nabonil Chatterjee, a 38-year-old product manager from Gurugram, discovered this the hard way. Alarmed by the tingling and numbness running down one arm, he went online and found videos and threads that convinced him that long hours at his desk had given him a posture problem. He changed his pillows, followed stretching routines, bought a neck brace, and delayed seeing a specialist for weeks. When he finally sought medical help, he was diagnosed with nerve compression requiring targeted treatment. Orthopaedic clinics regularly come across patients like Chatterjee who have treated themselves through generic internet fixes. "Performing inappropriate exercises," says Dr Jha, "can aggravate the problem, sometimes leading to increased inflammation, muscle spasms, or nerve compression." A reel showing stretches for knee pain may help one viewer but worsen pain for someone who may have ligament damage or arthritis.

Women's health specialists encounter patients who are convinced they are in the midst of hormonal catastrophe. Whatever their symptom, there is a social media reel, symptom checklist or chatbot explanation for it. "It is increasingly common to see patients come in with a self-diagnosis, especially around conditions like PMOS, thyroid disorders or perimenopause. Many women tend to match symptoms such as irregular periods, weight gain, acne, or mood changes with what they read online," says Dr Tripti Raheja, director-obstetrics and gynaecology at C.K. Birla Hospital. And sometimes such self-diagnosis becomes a medical emergency. As it did for a 29-year-old South Delhi professional, who, after a delayed period and online symptom searches, realised she was pregnant and procured abortion pills, without a consultation or ultrasound. Hours later, after severe cramps and heavy bleeding, she landed up at the hospital. Dr Anita Gupta, senior director–obstetrics & gynaecology, Fortis La Femme, New Delhi, says such cases are deeply concerning. Women may not be pregnant at all, may have an ectopic pregnancy, or may be at a gestation stage where pills are unsafe or ineffective. They then come with incomplete abortion, retained tissue or uncontrolled bleeding, with some cases requiring suction evacuation or emergency surgery.



"Partial, unverified information through AI can have serious public health consequences, especially in an era of antimicrobial resistance driven by misuse and overuse of antibiotics"

SARANSH CHAUDHARY, *CEO, Venus Remedies*

With all the rage around GLP-1 drugs like Ozempic and Wegovy, weight and metabolic conditions are another area where self-directed routines are common. "People should not be taking medication for weight loss or diabetes without consulting a doctor," says Dr Jasjeet Wasir, chairman of endocrinology at Medanta Hospital in Gurugram. "If weight or blood sugar is a concern, following online routines and repeatedly gaining and losing weight can do more harm than good. It is better to have a structured plan guided by a doctor, which will improve health as well as peace of mind."

Psychiatry offers another version of the problem. A 20-year-old college student spent weeks consuming short videos on adult ADHD. She began to reinterpret ordinary procrastination, boredom, restlessness and missed